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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): CASE XII: PARENTAL CONTROL OF MARRIAGE

Today, in the progressive areas, there seems to be little feeling against marriages in which a confusion of generations is involved, and this is perhaps an indication of the growing disorganization of the matrilineal groups. One progressive man snorted when told of one of his contemporaries who objected to the marriage of his daughter to a youngster who ranked as his 'brother' and the girl's 'father' through the identification of alternate generations. The progressive insisted that nothing was wrong with this type of marriage, and was indeed busily engaged in arranging a comparable one for his son. He maintained that all that was important was to be sure that people were of different clans. In the old society such a marriage would have led to utter confusion in behaviour, for the son would have become a 'brother-in-law' of his father's generation, and thus on a joking relationship basis with them. The marriage which they should negotiate as *basyanausi* of their son would involve them in the affairs of their 'sister' with which they were forbidden to meddle. They might be brought into conflict with the generation of their 'mother's brothers' who had the right to control the marriage. The old rules which prevented the two generations of a matrilineal group from appearing as *basimukowa* and *basyanausi* in the same marriage also prevented the possibility of such conflicts. Today with the greater degree of individual independence, such considerations are falling into the background.

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Marriages between a real grandparent and grandchild have always been considered wrong, and possibly incestuous, and this is still true today. Marriages between classificatory relatives of this type have always been accepted and even to some extent preferred. ■ [323](#) Today they are still

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accepted, but there is no feeling that they are specially to be desired, for it is no longer considered important to marry with those with whom some kinship link already exists.

Grandparents And
Grandchildren

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